Jacoby Transfers

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Jacoby Transfers are used after a player has opened or overcalled a natural 1NT and his partner holds at least one 5-card major suit. Responder naturally wants his side to play in his long suit, but with a weak hand, he would prefer his partner to play the contract. The reasoning is this: If the weak hand plays the contract, the strong hand becomes dummy and exposes its high card points and tenaces to the defenders. If the strong hand plays the contract, however, the weak hand becomes the dummy and the opponents have a harder time locating the high cards.

Jacoby Transfers work as follows. In response to 1NT:

Response	Meaning
2♦	5+ hearts. Asks partner to bid 2♥.
2♥	5+ spades. Asks partner to bid 2♠.

Opener's Rebids

Opener must complete the transfer by bidding 2♥ or 2♠. However, opener can make a super-acceptance bid of 3♥ or 3♠ if holding 4-card support and 17 points. Some experts like Marty Bergen espouse an approach of making a super-accept whenever holding 4-card support, in accordance with the Law of Total Tricks. Of course, this is up to partnership agreement.

Responder's Rebids

Responder's rebids after

1NT : 2♦
2♥ : ?

Rebid	Meaning
Pass	A weak hand with 5+ hearts. Opposite a strong 1NT, this shows 0-7 points.
2♠	An invitational hand with 5 hearts and 5 spades. Opposite a strong 1NT, this shows 8-9 points. Non-forcing.
2NT	A balanced or semi-balanced distribution, 5 hearts, and invitational. Partner can pass, sign off in 3♥ or bid 3NT.
3♣	5+ hearts, 4+ clubs and game-forcing.
3♦	5+ hearts, 4+ diamonds and game-forcing.
3♥	6+ hearts, invitational. Partner can pass or bid 4♥.
3♠	Not a part of the original convention, but can be played as a singleton/void in spades with slam interest.
3NT	A balanced or semi-balanced (no singletons or voids) distribution with 5 hearts. Partner can pass or correct to 4♥.
4♥	6+ hearts, signoff.

4NT	Quantitative, inviting slam in hearts or no-trumps. Partner is also allowed to correct to 5♥.

Responder's rebids after

1NT : 2♥
2♠ : ?

Rebid	**Meaning**
Pass	A weak hand with 5+ spades. Opposite a strong 1NT, this shows 0-7 points.
2NT	A balanced or semi-balanced (no singletons or voids) distribution, 5 spades, and invitational. Partner can pass, sign off in 3♠ or bid 3NT.
3♣	5+ spades, 4+ clubs and game forcing.
3♦	5+ spades, 4+ diamonds and game forcing.
3♥	5+ spades, 5+ hearts and game forcing with slam interest. This is stronger than jumping directly to 4♥.
3♠	6+ spades, invitational. Partner can pass or bid 4♠.
3NT	A balanced or semi-balanced (no singletons or voids) distribution with 5 spades. Partner can pass or correct to 4♠.
4♥	5+ spades and 5+ hearts with game values. Partner can pass or bid 4♠.
4♠	6+ spades, signoff.
4NT	Quantitative, inviting slam in spades or no-trumps. Partner is also allowed to correct to 5♠.

Examples

Opener	Responder
♠AJT	♠972
♥K76	♥QJ932
♦QT74	♦K5
♣AK3	♣654

Opener	Responder
1NT	2♦ (1)
2♥ (2)	Pass

1. Jacoby Transfer to hearts
2. Completing the transfer

Opener	Responder
♠AJT5	♠KQ832
♥K432	♥Q8
♦A9	♦T875
♣AJ7	♣92

Opener	Responder
1NT	2♥ (1)
3♠ (2)	4♠
Pass	

1. Jacoby Transfer to spades
2. Super-acceptance with 4-card support and a maximum

Opener	Responder
♠93	♠AJT52
♥AK2	♥QT954
♦KJ32	♦9
♣KJ85	♣76

Opener	Responder
1NT	2♦ (1)
2♥	2♠ (2)
3♥	Pass

1. Jacoby Transfer to hearts
2. Inviting game with 5 spades

Opener	Responder
♠KQ2	♠J9543
♥AKT	♥J754
♦98762	♦A3
♣A7	♣QJ

Opener	Responder
1NT	2♣ (1)
2♦ (2)	2♠ (3)
3♠	4♠

1. Use Stayman with 5-4 or 4-5 majors. Don't start with a transfer.
2. No 4-card major
3. Showing 5 spades and 4 hearts

In Competition

After 1NT is overcalled, transfers are off. If 1NT is doubled though, opinions vary. In "Modern Bridge Conventions", Bill Root and Richard Pavlicek say that a transfer "can never be preceded by interference." In the SAYC bidding booklet by the ACBL, however, transfers (and all conventional responses) are "on" over a double.

If the artificial transfer bid is doubled, the 1NT bidder can pass with only two-card support, redouble to show a good holding in the artificial transfer suit, or complete the transfer by bidding 2♥ or 2♠ with at least three-card support.

If the artificial transfer bid is overcalled, the 1NT bidder can pass with only two-card support, double for penalty or complete the transfer at the three-level with at least three-card support and a very good hand.

Extra Tips

1. Jacoby Transfers are also used after an opening bid of 2NT or 3NT, as well as strong notrump rebids by an opening 2♣ (artificial and strong) bid.

   2NT : 3♦/♥

   3NT : 4♦/♥

   2♣ : 2♦
   2NT : 3♦/♥

2♣ : 2♦
3NT : 4♦/♥

2. Note that Stayman, not transfers, should be used with hands that are 4-5 or 5-4 in the majors.

3. Beginners are prone to forget transfers when they come up, resulting in some very unhappy contracts. If you are a novice and decide to use transfer bids, be sure to remember them when they come up.

Origins

Jacoby Transfers were invented by American expert Oswald Jacoby.

See also

- Four-Suit Transfers
  Artificial transfers into all four suits.
- Jacoby 2NT
  Another convention invented by Oswald Jacoby. An artificial game-forcing raise in response to a major-suit opening bid.
- Minor Suit Transfers
  Transfers into clubs or diamonds, used after partner opens 1NT.
- South African Texas Transfers
  A variation of Texas using 4♣ and 4♦ bids.
- Texas Transfers
  Conventional major-suit transfers at the 4-level.